

Edible Wild Plants

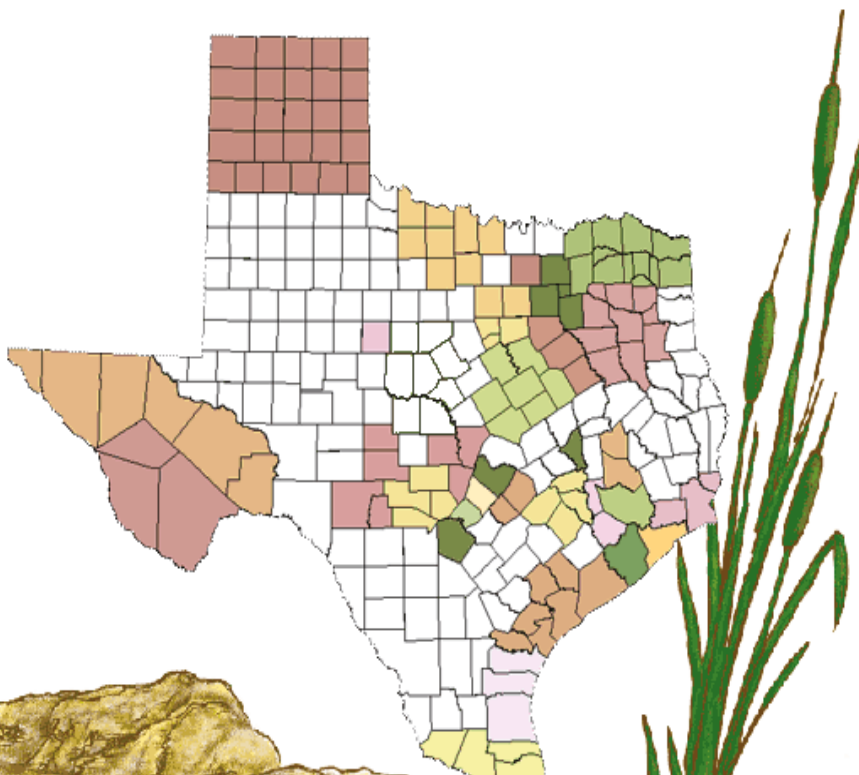
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Texas Master Naturalist

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Coastal Prairie Reporter

Click on the link below to download the latest Coastal Prairie Reporter (pdf format). Adobe Reader is required to view this file. If you do not have this software, you can get it free by clicking [HERE](#).

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Start

16 Biggest Hits

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7:30 PM

American Hackberry (*Celtis occidentalis*)

- Leaves
 - simple (undivided),
 - alternate (configured singly),
 - pointed,
 - finely toothed (serrated)
 - leaves' bases are distinctly uneven: one half is always longer or shorter than the other.



American Hackberry



- Medium sized tree
- Grows throughout the northeastern US
- Warty, light gray bark and messy-looking twigs
- Grows in parks, fields, floodplains, along fence rows, and in wastelands.

American Hackberry

- Use
 - Fruit - eaten raw. A mealy pleasant taste, small and insipidly sweet.
 - Fruit is about 10 mm in diameter with a single large seed.
 - An oil is obtained from the seed.
 - Some Medicinal Uses



Apples and Crabapples (*Malus species*)



- Medium-sized trees
- Bark gray, scaly, cracked
- Coarse, oval leaves,
 - pointed
 - slightly toothed, fuzzy underneath
 - 2 to 3-1/2 inches long;
- Flowers pink to white
 - 5-petaled
 - Radially-symmetrical
 - 3/4 inches across
 - Fragrant, in early spring
- Brown apple seeds in sets of 5 around core's circumference.

Apples and Crabapples



- Everyone recognizes apples, but how many can spot the tree without the fruit, or identify a crabapple with certainty?

Apples and Crabapples



- To make sure it's an apple and not a different fruit, imagine that it's the Earth, and slice it in half along the equator. The seeds and the holes that hold them will make a 5-parted circle.

Mayhaws

Crataegus aestivalis, *C. opaca*, and *C. rufula*.



Mayhaws



Folklore, medicinal uses.

- The Meskawakis indians used unripe *Crataegus tomentosa* fruit for bladder ailments
- Fruit also have hypotensive (lowers blood pressure) and antiarrhythmic activity (counters irregular heartbeat).
- Seeds of hawthorns are sometimes boiled or roasted, and made into a coffee-like beverage
- *Crataegus oxycantha* leaves are substituted for tobacco and smoked, causing a mild stimulant effect.

Mayhaws



Botanical description

- Plant: Medium sized spreading tree, to 30 ft. Overall appearance is very similar to a flowering crabapple tree.
- Flowers: Whitish-pink flowers are borne in profusion along 1-year wood and on short spurs. The floral structure is the same as apple.
- Pollination: Unclear; since most trees are grown from seed. Pollinator = honey bees.
- Fruit: a small, apple-like pome (1/2-1 inch); Bright red skin color, borne in "clusters" much like crabapples [actually, they're borne on closely spaced spurs, giving this appearance]. Ripens in May.

Chicory

Cichorium intybus

Description:

- Grows up to 1.8 meters tall.
- Leaves clustered at the base of the stem.
- The base leaves resemble those of the dandelion.
- Flowers are sky blue and stay open only on sunny days.
- Has a milky juice.

Edible Parts:

- All parts are edible.
- Eat the young leaves as a salad or boil to eat as a vegetable.
- Cook the roots as a vegetable.
- For use as a coffee substitute, roast the roots until they are dark brown and then pulverize them.



Cattail

Typha latifolia



Description:

- Grasslike plants with strap-shaped leaves 1 to 5 centimeters wide
- Growing up to 1.8 meters tall.
- Male flowers are borne in a dense mass above the female flowers.
- Female flowers that develop into the brown cattail.

Edible Parts:

- The young tender shoots are edible raw or cooked.
- The rhizome is often very tough but is a rich source of starch.
 - Pound the rhizome to remove the starch and use as a flour.
- The pollen is also an exceptional source of starch.
- When the cattail is immature and still green, you can boil the female portion and eat it like corn on the cob.

Canna lily

Canna indica



Description:

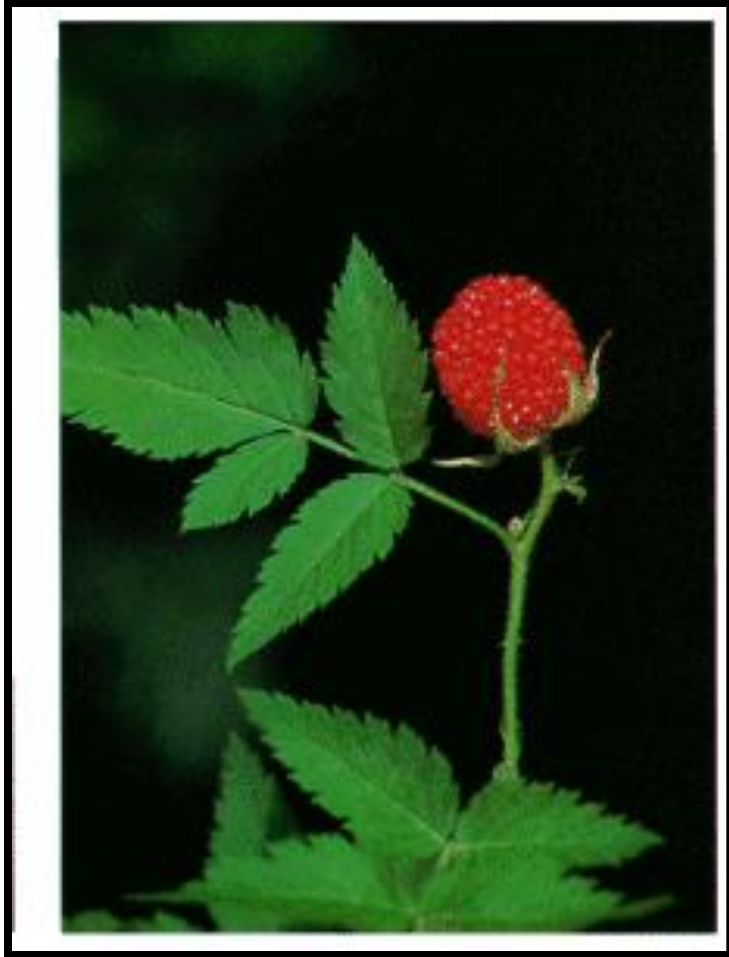
- A coarse perennial herb
 - 90 centimeters to 3 meters tall.
- Large leaves resemble those of the banana plant but are not so large.
- The flowers of wild canna lily are usually small and brightly colored reds, oranges, or yellows.

Edible Parts:

- The large and much branched rootstocks are full of edible starch.
- The younger parts may be finely chopped and then boiled or pulverized into a meal.

Blackberry and dewberry

Rubus species



Description:

- Plants have prickly stems (canes) that grow upward, arching back toward the ground.
- Alternate, usually compound leaves.
- Fruits may be red, black, yellow, or orange.

Edible Parts:

- The fruits and peeled young shoots are edible.
- Flavor varies greatly.

Other Uses:

- Use the leaves to make tea.
- To treat diarrhea, drink a tea made by brewing the dried root bark of the blackberry bush.

Daylily

Hemerocallis fulva



Description:

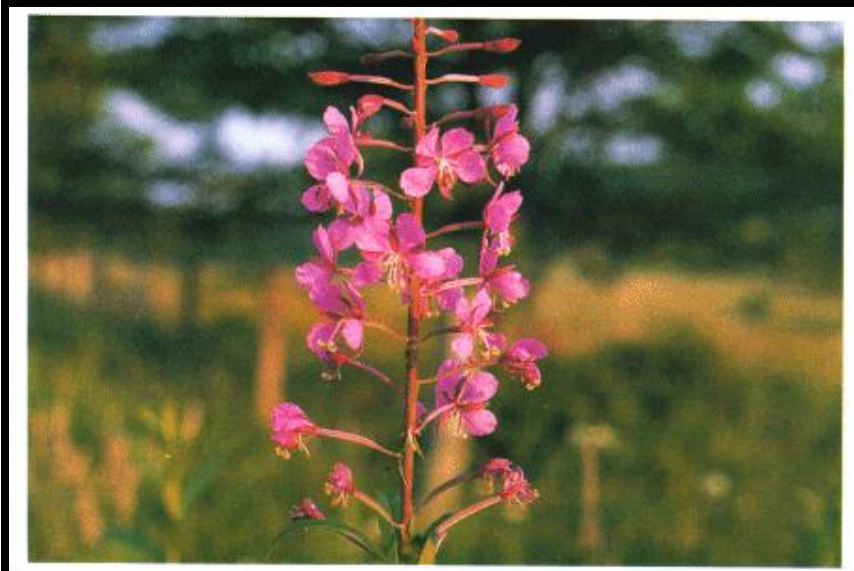
- Unspotted, tawny blossoms that open for 1 day only.
- Long, swordlike, green basal leaves.
- Root is a mass of swollen and elongated tubers.

Edible Parts:

- The young green leaves are edible raw or cooked.
- Tubers are also edible raw or cooked.
- You can eat its flowers raw, but they taste better cooked.

Fireweed

Epilobium angustifolium



Description:

- Grows up to 1.8 meters tall.
- Large, showy, red or pink flowers and lance-shaped leaves.
- Its relative, the dwarf fireweed (*Epilobium latifolium*), grows 30 to 60 centimeters tall.

Edible Parts:

- The leaves, stems, and flowers are edible in the spring but become tough in summer.
- You can split open the stems of old plants and eat the pith raw.

Juniper

Juniperus species



Description:

- Sometimes called cedars
- Trees or shrubs with very small, scalelike leaves densely crowded around the branches.
- Each leaf is less than 1.2 centimeters long.
- All species have a distinct aroma
- The berrylike cones are usually blue and covered with a whitish wax.

Edible Parts:

- The berries and twigs are edible.
- Eat the berries raw or roast the seeds to use as a coffee substitute.
- Use dried and crushed berries as a seasoning for meat.
- Gather young twigs to make a tea.

Mulberry

Morus species

Description:

- Tree with alternate, simple, often lobed leaves with rough surfaces.
- Its fruits are blue or black and many seeded.

Edible Parts:

- The fruit is edible raw or cooked.
- It can be dried for eating later.



Oak

Quercus species

Description:

- Trees have alternate leaves and acorn fruits.
- Two main groups of oaks: red and white.
 - Red oak group has leaves with bristles and smooth bark in the upper part of the tree.
 - White oak group has leaves without bristles and a rough bark in the upper portion of the tree.



Edible Parts:

- All parts are edible, but often contain large quantities of bitter substances.
- White oak acorns usually have a better flavor than red oak acorns.
- Gather and shell the acorns.
- Soak red oak acorns in water for 1 to 2 days to remove the bitter substance.
- You can speed up this process by putting wood ashes in the water in which you soak the acorns.
- Boil the acorns or grind them into flour and use the flour for baking.
- You can use acorns that you baked until very dark as a coffee substitute.

CAUTION

- Tannic acid gives the acorns their bitter taste.
- Eating an excessive amount of acorns high in tannic acid can lead to kidney failure.

Persimmon

Diospyros virginiana and other species



Description:

- Trees have alternate, dark green, elliptic leaves with entire margins.
- The flowers are inconspicuous.
- The fruits are orange, have a sticky consistency, and have several seeds.

Edible Parts:

- The leaves are a good source of vitamin C.
- The fruits are edible raw or baked.
- To make tea, dry the leaves and soak them in hot water.
- You can eat the roasted seeds.

Bamboo

Various species including
Bambusa, *Dendrocalamus*,
Phyllostachys

Bamboo

Various species including *Bambusa*, *Dendrocalamus*, *Phyllostachys*



Description:

- Woody grasses that grow up to 15 meters tall.
- The leaves are grasslike
- Stems are the familiar bamboo used in furniture and fishing poles.

Edible Parts:

- The young shoots of almost all species are edible raw or cooked.
- Raw shoots have a slightly bitter taste that is removed by boiling.
- To prepare, remove the tough protective sheath that is coated with tawny or red hairs.
- The seed grain of the flowering bamboo is also edible.
- Boil the seeds like rice or pulverize them, mix with water, and make into cakes.

Sassafras

Sassafras albidum



Description:

- Shrub or small tree bears different leaves on the same plant.
- Some leaves have:
 - one lobe
 - some two lobes
 - some no lobes.
- The flowers, which appear in early spring, are small and yellow.
- The fruits are dark blue.
- The plant parts have a characteristic root beer smell.

Edible Parts:

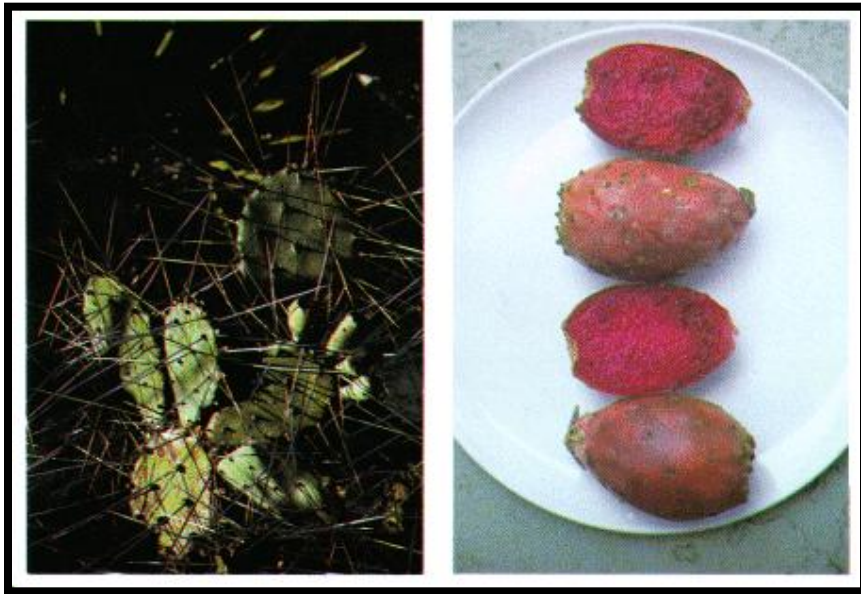
- The young twigs and leaves are edible fresh or dried.
- You can add dried young twigs and leaves to soups and gumbo.
- Dig the underground portion, peel off the bark, and let it dry. Then boil it in water to prepare sassafras tea.

Other Uses:

- Shred the tender twigs for use as a toothbrush.

Prickly pear cactus

Opuntia species



Description:

- Cactus has flat, padlike stems that are green.
- Many round, furry dots that contain sharp-pointed hairs cover these stems.

Edible Parts:

- All parts of the plant are edible.
- Peel the fruits and eat them fresh or crush them to prepare a refreshing drink or jam.
- Avoid the tiny, pointed hairs.
- Roast the seeds and grind them to a flour.

CAUTION

- Avoid any prickly pear cactus like plant with milky sap.

Pokeweed

Phytolacca americana



Description:

- This plant may grow as high as 3 meters.
- Its leaves are elliptic and up to 1 meter in length.
- It produces many large clusters of purple fruits in late spring.

Edible Parts:

- The young leaves and stems are edible cooked.
- Boil them twice, discarding the water from the first boiling.

CAUTION

- All parts of this plant are poisonous if eaten raw.
- Never eat the underground portions of the plant as these contain the highest concentrations of the poisons.
- Do not eat any plant over 25 centimeters tall or when red is showing in the plant.
- Use extreme caution.

Pine

Pinus species



Description:

- Trees are easily recognized by their needlelike leaves grouped in bundles.
- Each bundle may contain one to five needles, the number varying among species.
- The tree's odor and sticky sap provide a simple way to distinguish pines from similar looking trees with needlelike leaves.

Edible Parts:

- The seeds of all species are edible.
- You can collect the young male cones, which grow only in the spring, as a survival food.
- Boil or bake the young cones.
- The bark of young twigs is edible.
- Eat the seeds raw or cooked.
- Green pine needle tea is high in vitamin C.

Other Uses :

- Use the resin to waterproof articles.
- Also use it as glue.
- You can use hardened pine resin as an emergency dental filling.

Water lily

Nymphaea odorata



Description:

- These plants have large, triangular leaves that float on the water's surface
- Large, fragrant flowers that are usually white, or red
- Thick, fleshy rhizomes that grow in the mud.

Edible Parts:

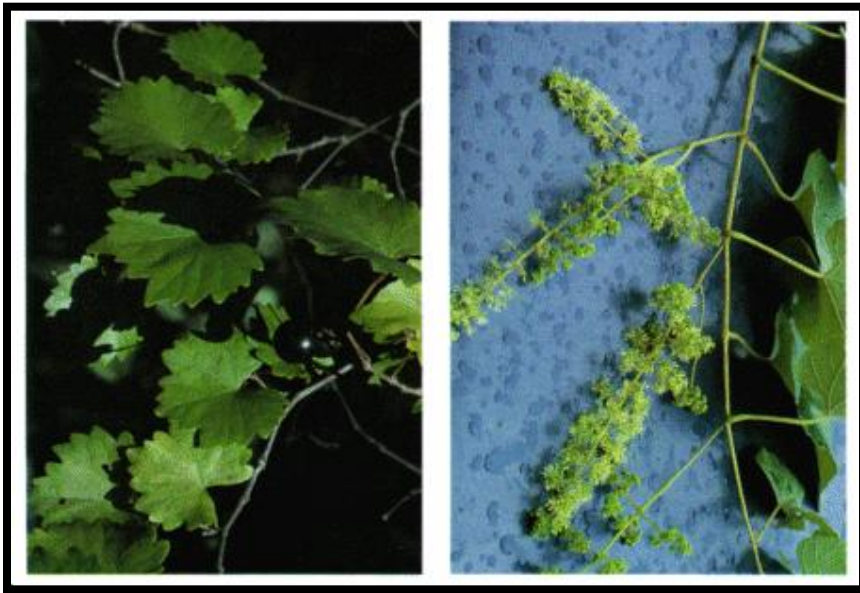
- The flowers, seeds, and rhizomes are edible raw or cooked.
- To prepare rhizomes for eating, peel off the corky rind.
- Eat raw, or slice thinly, allow to dry, and then grind into flour.
- Dry, parch, and grind the seeds into flour.

Other Uses:

- Use the liquid resulting from boiling the thickened root in water as a medicine for diarrhea and as a gargle for sore throats.

Wild grape vine

Vitis species



Description:

- The wild grape vine climbs with the aid of tendrils.
- Most grape vines produce deeply lobed leaves similar to the cultivated grape.
- Wild grapes grow in pyramidal, hanging bunches and are black-blue to amber, or white when ripe.

Edible Parts:

- The ripe grape can be eaten.
- Grapes are rich in natural sugars and, for this reason, are much sought after as a source of energy-giving wild food.
- None are poisonous.

Other Uses:

- You can obtain water from severed grape vine stems.
- Cut off the vine at the bottom and place the cut end in a container.
- Make a slant-wise cut into the vine about 1.8 meters upon the hanging part.
- This cut will allow water to flow from the bottom end. As water diminishes in volume, make additional cuts further down the vine.

CAUTION

- To avoid poisoning, do not eat grapelike fruits with only a single seed (moonseed).

Wild onion and garlic

Allium species



Description:

- *Allium cernuum* is an example of the many species of wild onions and garlics
- all easily recognized by their distinctive odor.

Edible Parts:

- The bulbs and young leaves are edible raw or cooked.
- Use in soup or to flavor meat.

CAUTION

- There are several plants with onionlike bulbs that are extremely poisonous.
- Be certain that the plant you are using is a true onion or garlic.
- Do not eat bulbs with no onion smell.

Wild rice

Zizania aquatica



Description:

- Wild rice is a tall grass
- Averages 1 to 1.5 meters in height, but may reach 4.5 meters.
- Its grain grows in very loose heads at the top of the plant and is dark brown or blackish when ripe.

Edible Parts:

- During the spring and summer, the central portion of the lower stems and root shoots are edible.
- Remove the tough covering before eating.
- During the late summer and fall, collect the straw-covered husks.
- Dry and parch the husks, break them, and remove the rice.
- Boil or roast the rice and then beat it into flour.

Wood sorrel

Oxalis species



Description:

- Wood sorrel resembles shamrock or four-leaf clover with a bell-shaped pink, yellow, or white flower.

Edible Parts:

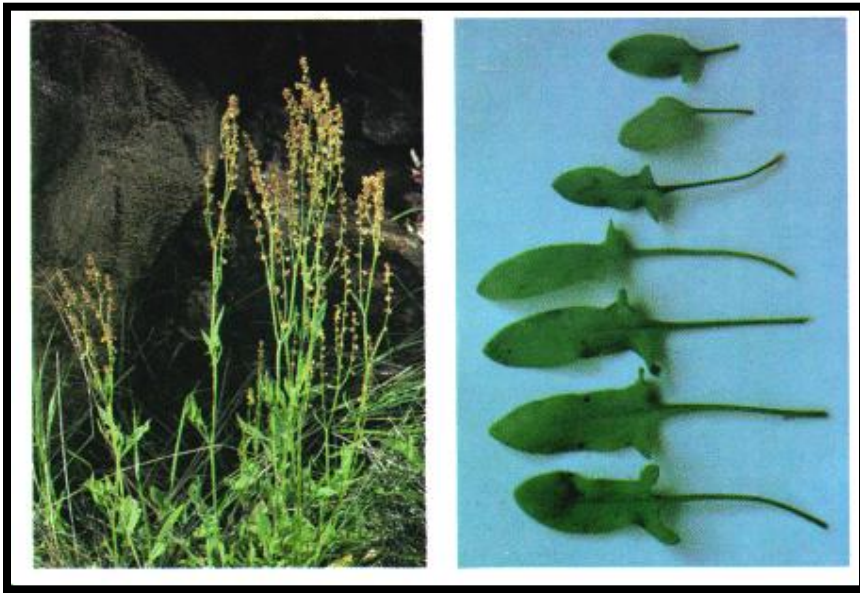
- Used in salads occasionally.
- Cook the entire plant.

CAUTION

- Eat only small amounts of this plant as it contains a fairly high concentration of oxalic acid that can be harmful.

Sheep sorrel

Rumex acerosella



Description:

- These plants are seldom more than 30 centimeters tall.
- They have alternate leaves, often with arrowlike bases
- Very small flowers, and frequently reddish stems.

Edible Parts:

The plants are edible raw or cooked.

CAUTION

- These plants contain oxalic acid that can be damaging if too many plants are eaten raw.
- Cooking seems to destroy the chemical.

Dandelion

Taraxacum officinale



Description:

- Leaves have a jagged edge
- Grow close to the ground and are seldom more than 20 centimeters long.
- Flowers are bright yellow.
- There are several dandelion species.

Edible Parts:

- All parts are edible.
- Eat the leaves raw or cooked.
- Boil the roots as a vegetable.
- Roots roasted and ground are a good coffee substitute.
- Dandelions are high in vitamins A and C and in calcium.

Other Uses:

- Use the white juice in the flower stems as glue.

Chufa

Cyperus esculentus



Description:

- Very common plant
- Triangular stem and grasslike leaves.
- It grows to a height of 20 to 60 centimeters.
- The mature plant has a soft furlike bloom that extends from a whorl of leaves.
- Tubers 1 to 2.5 centimeters in diameter grow at the ends of the roots.

Edible Parts:

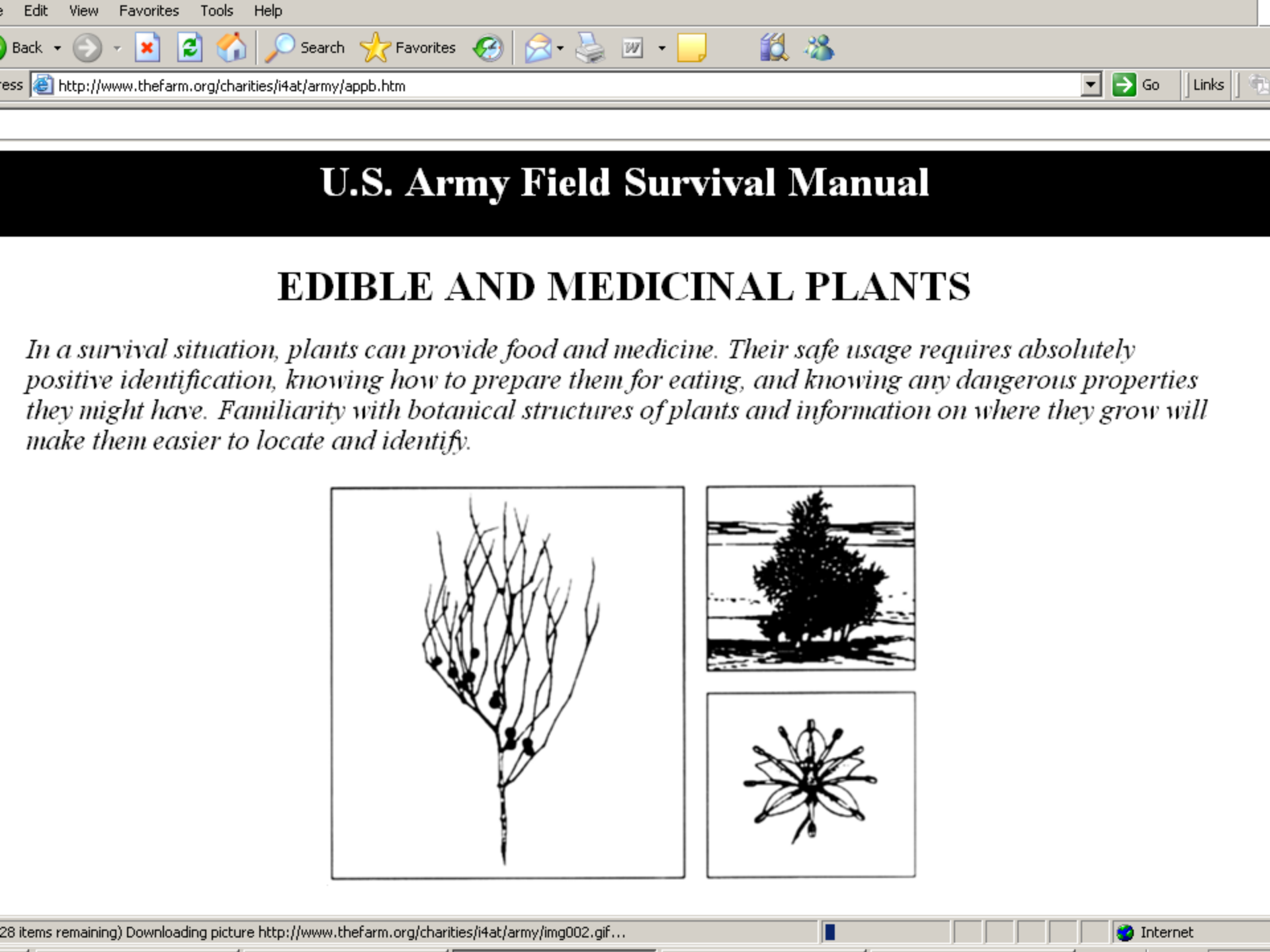
- The tubers are edible raw, boiled, or baked.
- You can also grind them and use them as a coffee substitute.

Emergency Medicinal Plant Uses

- *Diarrhea*
 - Drink tea made from the roots of blackberries and their relatives to stop diarrhea.
 - White oak bark and other barks containing tannin are also effective.
 - Eat white clay or campfire ashes.
- *Antiseptics* - for external use only.
 - Juice from wild onion or garlic
 - Juice from chickweed leaves or the crushed leaves of dock.
- *Fevers*. Treat a fever with a tea made from willow bark, an infusion of elder flowers or fruit, linden flower tea, or elm bark decoction.
- *Colds and sore throats*.
 - Willow bark
 - Make a tea made from burdock roots, mallow or mullein flowers or roots, or mint leaves.
- *Burns and Sunburn* –
 - Aloe vera sap.
 - Soak towels in boiled tea leaves
- *Sedatives*
 - Brewing a tea made from mint leaves or passionflower leaves.
- *Constipation*
 - Eat dandelion leaves, rose hips, or walnut bark.
 - Eating raw daylily flowers will also help.
- *Gas and cramps*
 - Use a tea made from carrot seeds as an antifatulent
 - Use tea made from mint leaves to settle the stomach.

Sources

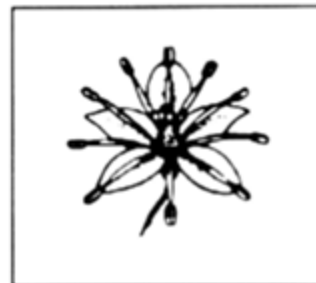
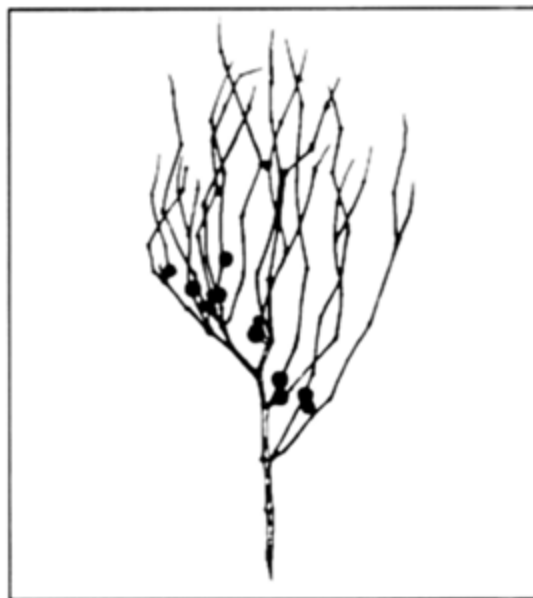
- Peterson Field Guide – Edible Wild Plants of Eastern/ Central North America
 - By Lee Allen Peterson
- Toxic Plants of Texas – TCE publication B-6105
- The following websites:
 - <http://www.wilderness-survival.net/plants-2.php>
 - <http://www.thefarm.org/charities/i4at/army/appb.htm>



U.S. Army Field Survival Manual

EDIBLE AND MEDICINAL PLANTS

In a survival situation, plants can provide food and medicine. Their safe usage requires absolutely positive identification, knowing how to prepare them for eating, and knowing any dangerous properties they might have. Familiarity with botanical structures of plants and information on where they grow will make them easier to locate and identify.





As Seen In: USA Today, Discovery Channel, US News & World Report

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PLANTS FOR MEDICINE

In a survival situation you will have to use what is available. In using plants and other natural remedies, positive identification of the plants involved is as critical as in using them for food. Proper use of these plants is equally important.